



NOT BROODING over his plight is Emil Panko, in Web-er's Restaurant as he discussed his reasons for jumping his New Orleans baseball farm club—Staff Photo by Al Car-lino.

Sports Ad Lib

by Bill Libby

Moe Wants Some Mo'

Currently AWOL from the Pirates' New Orleans farm club, Emil Panko, Yonkers' own baseball gypsy, is still paying off a 1954 Ford, as modest as any blinding junk car can be, but has his eyes on a Cadillac. "That's for me," he said. "I'll go for broke. I want to buy a home for mom and pop. I want a big car. In six or seven years I want to be able to open a business. You need money. Money, boy, that's the root of all evil."

This reporter, who incidentally drives a faded green 1950 Ford, which runs remarkably well, but is not adverse to speaking occasionally of large financial transactions, spent part of yesterday afternoon chatting with this husky, chunky, amiable young man, who, to say the least, has the courage of his convictions. When a photographer came to snap his picture, Moe pushed a beer out of range, doubtless not so much to preserve any aura of purity as to avoid rubbing anything in on his Pittsburgh house, who may read newspapers, too.

"I just want a square deal," Emil said. I don't want to sweat for nothing. I want the promotions I deserve and I want more money. I like baseball. It's a great life. I was better' good. They told me I'd made the New Orleans club. I don't want to quit. You make good money. Where could I get dough like that here? I couldn't get in two months what I make in a month playing ball. But I don't want to be pushed around."

A former student of Alex Joyner's at Saunders, this out-spoken young man got homer conscious and flopped with a .230 get-away in a dozen games in Winter Baseball in recent months, but threw in the towel, before, he said, he got all fouled up. His third minor league year last season with Williamsport in the Class A Eastern League was a sound one in which he hit .200, drove in more than 100 runs, hit 24 homers and had one of the highest slugging averages in his team's history. He felt this earned him a Spring Training spot with Pittsburgh, or at least a clear chance with Hollywood in the Triple-A Pacific Coast League.

He has read about bonus babies. "When I see what some of these guys get, forty, fifty thousand, and see what they can do I figure I'm worth as much. I read the papers and see the fel-lows I played with and against in training getting a chance with Brooklyn and the Yankees. I got four hundred when I signed. I could've had a thousand with Brooklyn—they offered me nine hundred—but I figured I could move up quicker with Pittsburgh. Well now I figure I'm getting pushed around. I'd love to get my release. I figure I could get five thousand from some club now. I'd send Rikky half my bonus money if he'd release me."

Emil stalled and argued before accepting a New Orleans Double-A Southern Association pact for \$850 a month—\$500 if he makes the grade—but after a week in training at Hustaville, Texas, jumped the club and flew home.

The Right Move...

When reminded that the hand-box parks in the Southern Association make attractive targets, he seemed unconcerned. "A small park isn't so good. You catch yourself looking at those fences. It don't really matter. The way I hit 'em it doesn't make any difference. When I catch one good it either goes way over the wall or stops just in front of it. I don't need a small fence."

"I figure I'd be wastin' a year in New Orleans. If I had a bad year I'd stay there. If I had a good year I'd move up to Hollywood only. They called up guys who didn't do as well as I did. I think I made the right move. They're businessmen. Base-ball's a business. They don't want to give you any more than they have to. I want a Hollywood contract for 800 a month and next year I want a Pittsburgh contract. If not I'll quit. I want that sixty-five hundred minimum. I told 'em I know what they'll do. They'll send me to Hollywood just to do it and then they'll send me back to New Orleans."

"I'll rather play in Hollywood. You travel better. You live better. You make more money. I've had three years in the minors. I figure two of 'em were real good. Not great, but real good," he wrapped his small, strong hands around his beer and sipped it and looked wistful. "I'm getting stronger. I'm only twenty-one. I hit 24 homers last year, this year I figure I'll hit 38. I found myself hitting the ball on the handle and knocking it over the fence. My timing's getting better. I figure I should hit more homers every year."

"You know," he said, thinking hard about it, knitting the brows on his handsome, soft young face. "I think I could make the majors right now. Think? I'm sure I could. I could. They don't have so much. They've got Thomas and who else have they got. They have Clemente and he's supposed to be a good prospect, but who else? Some of those guys they got and kept hit .230, .260. They called up Mejias and he didn't hit as well as I did. He hit .260. So he hit in 56 straight games with Waco, so what? I figure I could go up there right now and hit .260."

The mediocre Pirates have outfield problems for sure. Thomas hit .245, Clemente .255 and Mejias .216. John Powers hit .205 for Williamsport in a 32-game stint as Panko's teammate and was promoted to the Bus variety this Spring.

The Discussions

"They told me I shouldn't feel this way, but I told them I do," he said. His manager, Andy Cohen, wouldn't talk to him when he left. His father was a little peeved when he showed up home. "I asked them why I didn't move up faster. They said they were satisfied with me. They were only worried about my health. I told 'em my health was fine. They said you've had trouble with your back and legs. I said I didn't have trouble last year. They said when they call Panko up, they want to see the real Panko. I asked them why couldn't Hollywood see the real Panko?"

Moe said he no longer has the pain in his back and legs, which has pestered him in the past. He noted that he's a little musclebound, but that if he takes a 20-minute warmup he loosens up fine. He's 15 pounds overweight at 185, but figures he could sweat that off in a hurry. "I figured when I got to Texas I'd talk it over with McCharrick (a key Pittsburgh scout), but he had some illness in the family and had to leave. I figured I wasn't getting anywhere, so I came home. I don't think they'll let me go. McCharrick called up Wednesday night and said I shouldn't feel the way I do but he'd talk to the bosses and see what he could do. I figure I'll hear from him soon."

Panko seems cheerful and hopeful. "Hollywood isn't any faster than New Orleans, just smarter. They're tough there. They'll thrash you back and knock you down. They have a lot of fights." He smiled as he thought about it. Branch Rickey, as he figures, of getting there are increased if Branch Rickey, as he figures, still has a say, because he always did well when Rikky watched him. "He moved me up to Class A when I was supposed to get to C. Boy, can that man talk! It's really something to listen to him. You can't say anything, but you sure learn. He said he figured I could make A and I did."

We formed the opinion, with unfortunate Bus farmhands in Indianapolis, that no one has developed the technique of ruining young talent as effectively as the Pirates, whose recent record of success with rookies is a testament to their skill. However, young talent has been known to destroy itself and some rash persons have leaped to the conclusion that patience is not one of Moe's great virtues. Our Marv Schneider, who does his major shopping in the same candy store Emil patronizes and has been on Panko's story from the beginning felt he understood the Pirate attitude when he quoted Emil Wednesday, as saying "Monday night I told them I was quitting and early Tuesday morning this guy hands me my plane ticket!" Emil indicated yesterday, however, that the pain he felt sitting on his wallet all the way home was not because it was bulging.

"I paid my own way when I came home," he said. "A hundred bucks. That's another thing. I told them I want to be reim-bursed. I don't have any dough. I'm broke. I could use that hundred bucks. When they call me back I want them to pay my travel money."